

# Messing with your Morphosyntax

Evidence from Greek–Coptic & Iranian–Armenian contact

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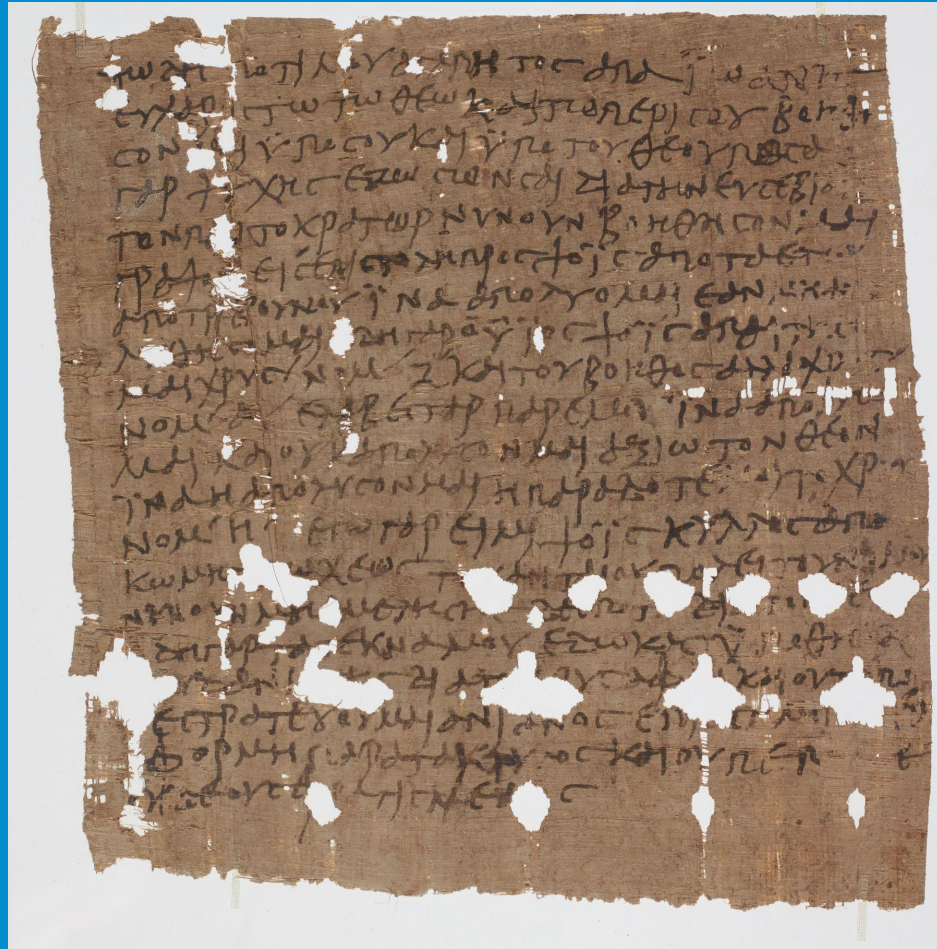
Multilingualism and structural change:  
insights from past histories and present realities

Lausanne, 27 March 2023

# Introduction

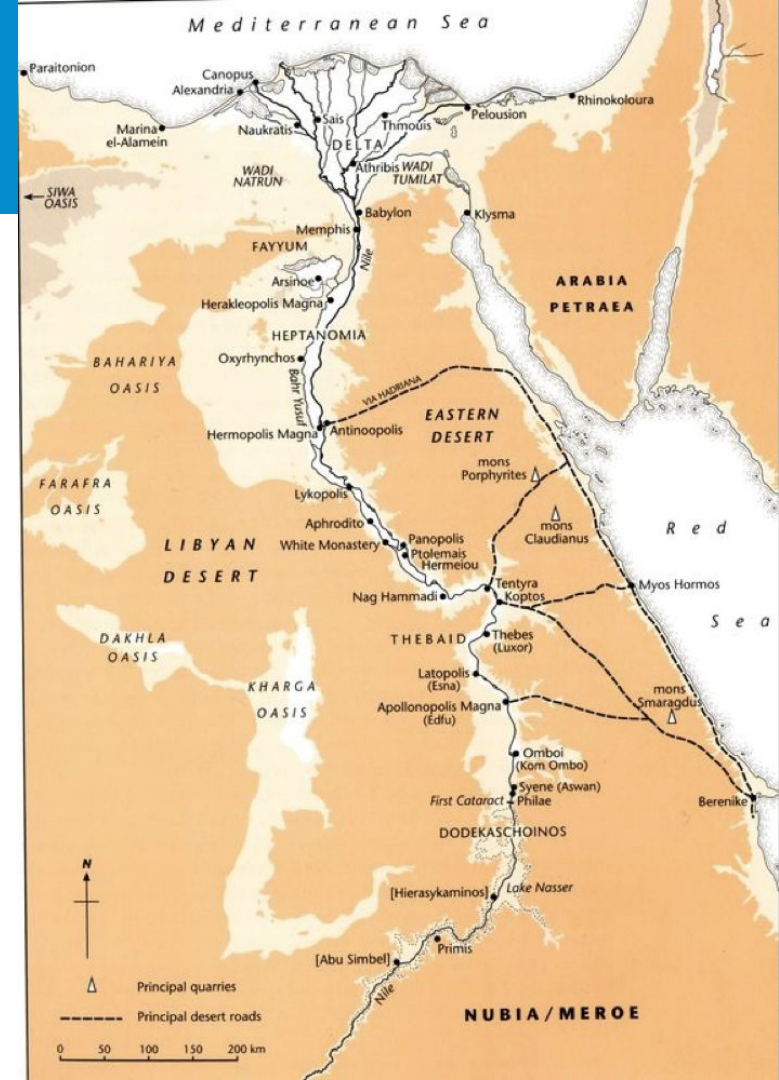
- What type of contact setting are we looking at?  
What aspects would characterise the setting as intense language contact?
  - Corpus languages
  - Long-term contact
  - Hierarchical setting (H – L)
  - Indo-European target language
- What areas of the morpho-syntax are we going to talk about?
  - Inflection of arguments and adjuncts
  - Relative clauses
  - Support-verb constructions
  - Morphosyntactic alignment
- What do we want to show you?
  - Different outcomes both sociolinguistically and systemically
  - Potential extent and severity of contact-induced morphosyntactic change

# Greek & Coptic in Egypt



# Setting the scene

- Context: Egypt, AD 300–650 (contact situation for about a millennium)
  - Socio-cultural → e.g. Christianity (Depauw and Clarysse 2013)
  - Socio-political → e.g. wills (Garel and Nowak 2017)
  - Socio-linguistic → writing system, educational backing, political backing (Matras 2009)
- Language contact surfaces as singular instances rather than a systemic change.
- Outcome: language death / takeover by Arabic (Papaconstantinou 2012, Sijpesteijn 2007).
- Corpus: bilingual papyrus archives, private letters



# Types of contact features

- Direct interferences (one-offs): polysemy copying

The man **on** the picture

**sur** la photo

**auf** dem Bild

- Indirect interferences (one-offs): pivot-matching

προσγορεύω + **dative**

προσγορεύω + accusative

ϣινε ε-/ερο= *šine e-/ero*=

→ πρὸς ‘to / towards’ / ε-/ερο= *e-/ero*= ‘to / towards’

→ no prepositional item to mark direct objects in Greek

- Convergence (diachronically stable)

# Direct interferences (one-offs): polysemy copying

P. Herm. 7, ll. 6–8 (Lykopolis, AD 381, letter)

γράψον **εἷς ἐπιστολὴν πρὸς** **Ψοῖς** ἀπὸ Ταετῶ **ἀπὸ** τριβούνου, (...).

‘Write a letter to Psois of Toeto, one of the *tribunes*, (...).’

→ inflecting objects

ce2-**ΟΥ-ΕΠΙΣΤΟΛΗ**

**Ν-ΠΣΑΙΣ**

ΠΑ-ΤΑΕΤΟ

ΠΑ-Ν-ΤΡΙΒΟΥΝΟΥ (...)

*seh-ou-epistolē*

*n-psais*

*pa-taeto*

*pa-n-tribounou (...)*

write.IMP-ART.IDF-letter

to.PRP-name

the.one.of-Toeto

the.one.of-ART.DEF.PL-tribun (...)

# Indirect interferences (one-offs): pivot-matching

P. Herm. 7, ll. 2–5 (Lykopolis, AD 381, letter)

**πάσας** γὰρ **ψυχῆς** ἔζωσων σαι διὰ τὴν εὐσέβειαν <πρὸς> τὸν παντοκράτωρ. νῦν οὖν βοήθησόν μαι·

‘For, **as regards all souls**, they always surround you because of (your) piety towards the Almighty. Therefore, help me now!

→ inflection in the left periphery

Grossmann 2015 no-case-before-the-verb rule

- **nci-** **nkji-** → postponed subject
- **n-/na=** **n-/na=** → indirect object
- **n-/mmo=** **n-/mmo=** → direct object

# Convergence (diachronically stable)

PSI 8 938, l. 7 (Aphrodites Kome, AD 501–600, letter)

ἀπάλλαξον δὲ αὐτοὺς καὶ ὧν χρεωστοῦνται **περὶ αὐτῶν**

‘Release them also from those things, concerning which they are still liable’

→ relative clauses with a resumptive pronoun

ὁ ἀνὴρ                      ὧν ὁρᾷς

π-ρωμε                      ετε-ναυ                      ερο-φ

*p-rōme*                      *ete-nau*                      *ero=f*

ART.DEF.SG-man    REL.2sg.f see                      DOM=3sg.m

‘the man who you (fem.) see’



# Convergence (diachronically stable; Egypt only)

P. Neph. 9, ll. 4–6 (Alexandria, AD 301–400, letter)

χάριν ὁμολογῶ τῇ θεῖα προνοίᾳ ὅτι με τὸν ἐλάχιστο(ν) κατηξιώσατε ὑπουργῆσαι ὑμῖν

‘I am grateful to the divine providence because you deemed me, the humblest one, worthy of serving you.’

→ support-verb construction [in the formulaic section of letters!] (regionalism)

Support-verb-construction families:

Greek χάριν: δίδωμι ‘to give’, ἔχω ‘to have’, λαμβάνω ‘to receive / to take’, BUT ὁμολογέω (literally) ‘to agree’

Coptic ⲉⲙⲟⲩ: ⲫ- ‘to give’, ⲉⲣ- ‘to do’, ⲭⲓ- ‘to receive’ AND ⲭⲣⲓ- ‘to get’

# Parthian & Armenian in Armenia



# Classical Armenian in Contact: Background

- Armenian is an Indo-European language
- heavily influenced by Iranian languages
- the extent of this influence is still under investigation but includes:
  - lexicon
  - phonology
  - derivational morphology
  - syntax
- Contact lasted  $\pm 1,000$  years (incl. Iranian hegemony and direct rule)
  - 66 CE: installation of a Parthian king
  - 224 CE: fall of the Parthian Empire, rise of the Sasanians
  - ~300 CE: Christianisation of Armenia & its rulers
  - 428 CE: imposition of direct Sasanian rule



Hübschmann (1875, 1897); Meillet (1911–12);  
Garsoïan (1997a,b); Russell (1997)

# Pattern replication in Classical Armenian

*Language contact can [...] lead to re-shaping of language-internal structures. [...] In this case] the patterns of distribution, of grammatical and semantic change, and of formal-syntactic arrangement at various levels [...] are modelled on an external source.*

(Matras & Sakel 2007:829–30)

- intensifier Armenian *ink'n* “-self” serves as anaphora and (to a lesser extent) as switch-function marker
  - exact parallel in Parthian *xwd* and Middle Persian *wxd* “-self; same”
- reflexive Armenian *anjn iwr* modelled on Parthian *xwyš gryw* “own body/self”
- complementiser Armenian *(e)t'ē* functions also as quotative and indirect statement/question marker
  - exact parallel in Parthian and Middle Persian *kw*
  - rare elsewhere

# Morphosyntactic Alignment: Basics

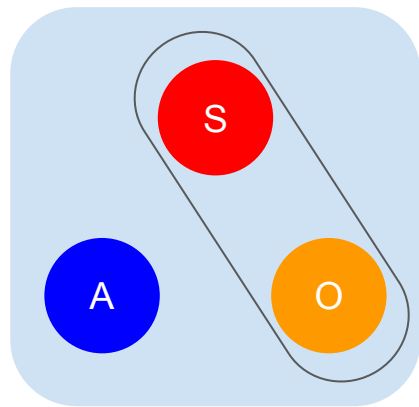
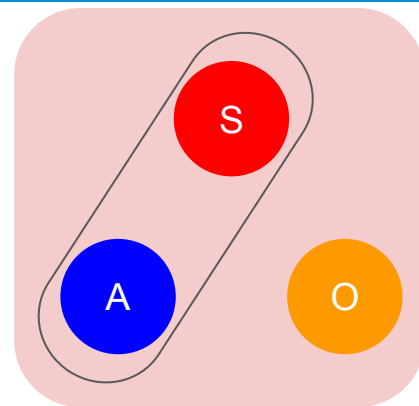
- Armenian, like many (but by no means all) Indo-European languages, shows **nominative–accusative alignment**
  - **Subject (S)** of an intransitive verb ~ **Agent (A)** of a transitive verb
  - **Object (O)** of a transitive verb
  - Engl.: “**Julia** runs.” – “**Julia** pets **the dog**.”  
Ger.: “**Julia** rennt.” – “**Julia** streichelt **den Hund**.”  
Lat.: “**Iulia** currit.” – “**Iulia** **canem** delenit.”
- **S & A** are treated identically (case, position, verb agreement, etc.), **O** differently.
  - “**Julia** pets **the dog**.” ≠ “**The dog** pets **Julia**.”
- **BUT:** it further exhibits something like **ergative–absolutive alignment** (also found in Hindi, varieties of Kurdish, Basque)
  - Here, in specific circumstances, **S & O** are treated identically, **A** differently.

# Morphosyntactic Alignment in Classical Armenian

- Synthetic tenses use **nominative–accusative** alignment
  - present, imperfect, aorist
  - **S=A** marked nominative
  - **O** marked accusative
- Analytical tenses use a different alignment
  - Perfect, pluperfect, (future perfect)
  - consist of participle and (optional) form of ‘to be’
  - historically analysed as **ergative–absolutive**, but...
  - **S=O** marked as nominative/accusative
  - **A** marked as genitive

**Problems:**

- nominative does not always equal accusative
- historical models do not account for data

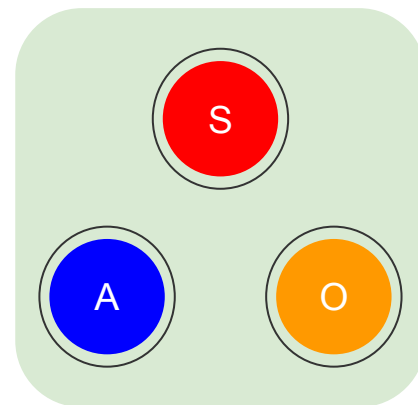


# Complications in the perfect

- **O** is marked nominative/accusative – but nominative  $\neq$  accusative everywhere
- **O** is often differentiated for definiteness – *the man* vs. *a man* (by proclisis)
- Lack of verb agreement: the finite form of ‘to be’ is invariable (when present)

## Result

- ergative-absolutive alignment is a minority pattern / misanalysis
- more accurate: tripartite alignment (**S** $\neq$ **A** $\neq$ **O**)
- tripartite alignment: not economical, rarely stable, common sign of transition / change-in-progress



# Examples & Observations

## (1) tripartite alignment

*oroy yankarc uremn ēr gteal nšanagirs alp‘ap‘etac‘ hayerēn lezui*  
rel.gen.sg unexpectedly somewhere be.3sg.pst find.ptcp sign.acc.pl alphabet.gen.pl Armenian language.gen.sg  
“... who unexpectedly somewhere had found the letters of the Armenian alphabet”

## (2) quasi ergative-absolutive alignment

*ew nora tueal hraman ark‘ayagund banakac‘=n*  
conj 3.gen.sg give.ptcp order.nom/acc.sg royal-guard army.dat.sg=det  
“And he gave an order to the royal army.”

- next to the expected patterns, there are also two other minority patterns:
  - **S** marked genitive (type: nominative-accusative) – incidence falling across 5th century CE
  - **A** marked nominative (type: nominative-accusative) – incidence rising across 5th century CE
- system pressure from synthetic tenses – transitional pattern

**Hypothesis:** orig. ergative-absolutive > trans. tripartite > result: nominative-accusative



# Replicating the past

## (3) Parthian (ergative-absolutive)

*qd tw 'br sd 'yy 'w=t 'z hyšt hym syywg*  
when 2sg up ascend.ptcp be.2sg.prs conj=2sg.obl 1sg.dir leave.ptcp be.1sg.prs orphan  
“When you ascended and left me an orphan...”

## (4) Parthian (ergative-absolutive, no finite verb)

*kw 'ym, cy=m 'c tw wx'st, 'w mn w'c'h*  
comp dem rel=1sg.obl from 2sg request.ptcp to 1sg.obl say.2sg.sbjv  
“... that which I requested from you, give it to me!”

## Commonalities

- participle as pivot of construction
  - participle can function as adjective
  - use of the copula, but not in the 3sg
  - TSA – tense-sensitive alignment split (non-past vs past)
  - object case differentiation limited, use of object-marking proclitic
  - agent case also used for marking appurtenance, possession
- } pivot matching & polysemy copying

# A superstrate shift

- historical and historiographical data point to the ‘death’ of Parthian in the region
  - no documents beyond the late 3rd century CE
  - identification with Armenians in opposition to other Iranians
  - Christianisation, wars against Sasanian Empire, intermarriage and tutelage together with Armenian nobles
- the Parthian rulers of Armenia adopted Armenian as their main language
- their variety was prestigious, their L2-idiosyncrasies were adopted by native speakers

## Comparanda:

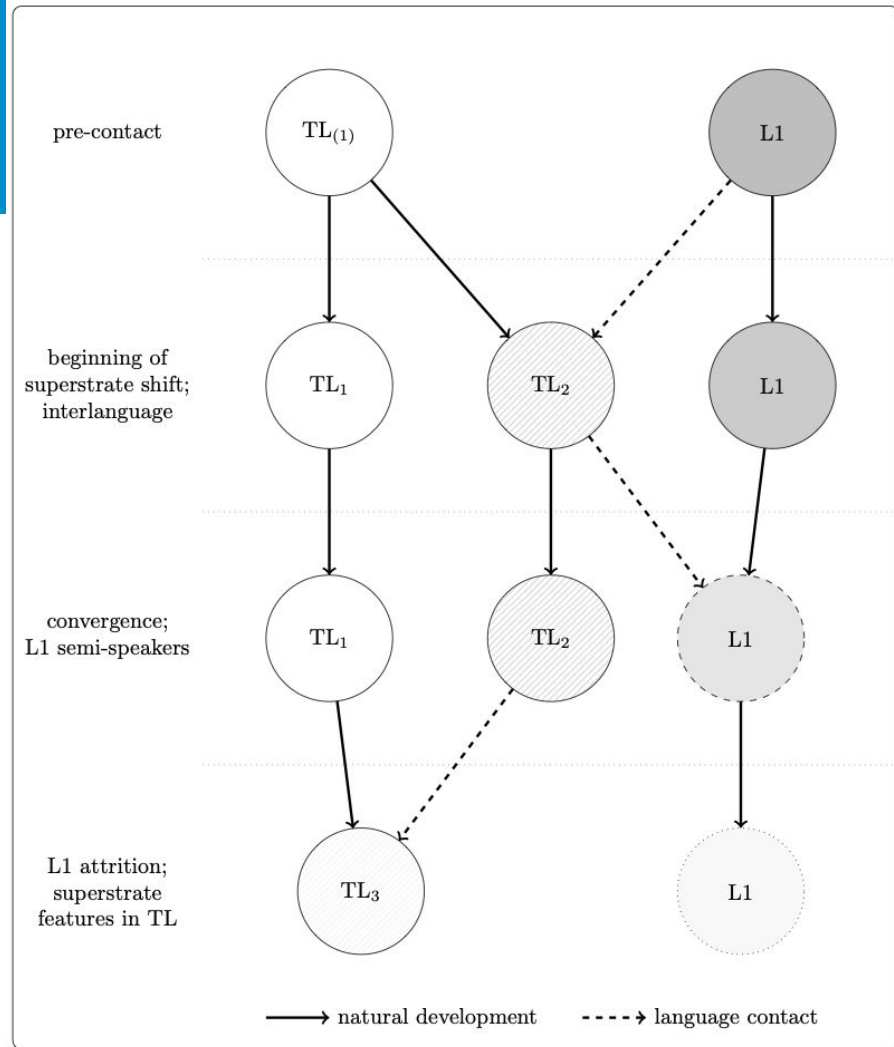
- Norman-French superstrate shift to English in the centuries after 1066 CE
- Similar replication processes in other languages in the Iranian periphery

# Takeaways

- historical / corpus languages offer limited data, limited conclusions
- even the best analysis needs extra-linguistic evidence for support
- contact-based explanations may offer new insights where internal attempts have failed
- uncommon  $\neq$  impossible (e.g. superstrate shifts)

## Iranian–Armenian contact explains:

- origin of perfect construction
- direction of its diachronic change
- lack of Parthian texts in the region



# Conclusion

|                                                                  | Greek – Coptic | Armenian – Parthian |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|---------------------|
| Long-term ( $\geq 1,000$ years) and hierarchical contact setting | YES            | YES                 |
| Systemic change through language contact                         | NO             | YES                 |
| Social surroundings of language contact (and change)             | Bottom-up      | Top-down            |

## Greek under the influence of Coptic:

- Greek inflecting objects (especially in the left, yet contact periphery) & inflecting relative pronouns contracts in the Ptolemaic period (ca. 300 BC to AD 0). formulaic contexts

## Armenian under the influence of Parthian:

- Parthian – Armenian based on high register analytical tenses
- Creates a split alignment system for the historiographic texts; attestation begins just prior to the end of the contact period.
- Replicates a small (?) number of other, unrelated patterns (anaphora, quotative)

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